pack our breakfast every morning. Dada and I never took the same food for our tiffins. Our demands always differed, and Maa never denied cooking separately for us. For the rest of the meals, there was a simple rule of acceptance, applicable to all members of the Saxena family. As always, Maa dropped us till the bus stop, which was just a minute away from home. As always, she made us carry our school bags and water bottles ourselves. As always, we kissed her goodbye and got into the bright yellow minibus from Tiny Tots when it arrived.

'He's on my seat, Dada,' I whispered on seeing a boy occupying my usual spot as we walked towards the back. Dada walked up to him and his intimidating stare was enough to get the seat vacated. My elder brother was also my unpaid personal bodyguard. Besides, Papaji's instructions included that he look out for me during school hours. The little devil that I was, I made full use of it. 'Next time, you better talk to people yourself,' Dada said as he helped me sit. 'Anyway, you remember what I told you yesterday, right?'

'Yes! I remember.' Like a dutiful sister, I punctuated my words with a nod.

'Good girl!' Dada said.

'Will you let me play with your friends then?' I tried to get reassurance for the terms from a day before. Dada's friends were the only friends I had. They would be my only friends for a long time to come.

'I will. I promise,' Dada said and extended his pinkie finger. I extended mine to lock it with his, and for the umpteenth time since the previous day, we bound ourselves into this agreement.

Dada had tasked me with a job I considered very important, so much so that I even forgot to pluck a flower for Titli Ma'am that day—all my focus was on the task at hand. Even though I didn't know how to read time on the clock, I knew when the bell for recess rang, since I remembered the position of the clock's arms. I kept staring at the wall clock through all the periods. As the clock's arms inched closer to the position, I took out my tiffin and readied myself for a sprint. The bell rang. The joy of recess converted into a collective cheer, which echoed from all directions. I got out of my seat and